

BEYOND THE FIRST YEAR: THE FIRST-GENERATION COLLEGE EXPERIENCE



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Abstract

Research indicates that first-generation, low-income college students remain at a disadvantage with maintaining enrollment and attaining degrees compared to their peers whose parents are college graduates. In this study, we conducted nine focus groups to explore the experience of first-generation college students at a large, public, Midwestern research university with attention to two significant questions: One, how might our institutions better serve first-generation students beyond their first year of college, where tremendous resources have already been allocated? Second, how might a peer mentoring program be beneficial to these students? Using interpretive critical research as a process and framework, preliminary analyses of the data yielded six meta-themes: (a) visible/invisible, (b) different worlds, (c) perpetual border crossers, (d) burden of privilege, (e) getting to know the system, and (f) a call to genuine institutional commitment. Each theme illustrates the unique challenges that these students face in persisting at a predominantly White institution.

Significance of the Study

✓ The benefits of obtaining a college degree include job stability, increased income, and professional mobility. Yet, for first-generation (FG), low-income (LI) students, persistence in college continues to be a greater challenge and obstacle, compared to their peers whose parents have a degree. College is an unknown experience for many FG students. They enter college with lower levels of academic preparation, are less likely to receive financial support, and more likely to have multiple obligations outside college, like family, and work. As a result FG students face challenges that make it difficult for them to be successful in college.

✓ Research indicates FG students remain at a disadvantage with maintaining enrollment and attaining degrees. This is a critical problem and the need to retain these students is very crucial for these reasons: (a) in order to work in a diverse society all students benefit from interaction and engagement with diverse peers throughout college, (b) FG students play a significant role in the construction of new knowledge in the academy, and lastly (c) first-generation students who graduate from four year institutions build their communities and also become contributing members of our economy.

Research Questions

This study examines the experience of first-generation, low-income college students at a large, public, Midwestern research university. There are two components to our study:

1.How might our institution better serve first-generation students beyond their first year of college, where tremendous resources have already been allocated?

2. How might a peer mentoring service be beneficial to these students beyond their first year?

Special Thanks to Steve Cisneros for his role in data collection/analysis, and to the 39 first-generation participants for their rich narratives.

Images Retrieved from Google

I didn't expect a University to be diverse, but I assumed it was. I read about it and it seemed diverse to me, but when we were in Mariucci and I was standing there and looking around, I couldn't like believe what I was seeing…It was not very diverse at all. It was difficult to find like another black person in the crowd. Not even next to you, or even in your section, but not even across from you.

-Mohamed, Male, Immigrant student

I am very fond of international news. I read it every day, CNN, Al Jazeera, Russian Times, and my mom asked me "Why do you look up international news because it doesn't pertain to you". So, its like we are obviously in such different worlds and I like I am endeavoring in all these scholarly pursuit and umm learning new things and I can't even really share it with my mom because she is just not understanding at the level that I am understanding it, or in just different ways.

-James, Male, African-American student

There is a University expectation from us, as a general student or student of color or student who are underrepresented, or even first-generation. We are expected to excel, but, at least I feel like the University gets less and less invested in us every single year, whether that be in scholarships or just different things that they have been doing over the past two and a half year that I have been here.

-Hana, Female, Immigrant student

Discussion

With the many challenges and obstacles first-generation, low-income students face it makes it difficult for them to be successful in college. Institutions need to find effective ways of bridging gaps between available resources and services that minimize these constraints. To truly embody the principle of democracy, higher education must provide equal and quality access to education for all students. There has been a significant body of research on the critical importance of the first year for retention of FG students. With the many programs focused on the first-year students, what happens to students beyond their first year? Preliminary analyses of data in this study suggests that strong pre-matriculation and first-year programmatic efforts to retain LI, FG students need to extend into the remainder of their collegiate experience. The necessity for a consistent and authentic support system could take the form of facilitated and institutionally funded peer-mentoring program to serve students for the duration of their collegiate career. Many LI, FG students reported the value in having a safe space where experienced FG students could guide less experienced students through various facets of the collegiate experience. The intent of such a program would be to utilize the experience of FG students, and help students become not only connected to resources and support, but they become a resource and support for each other.

Methods

This study employed a qualitative interpretive critical research approach to capture and understand the experience of first-generation students through conducting focus groups. The use of focus groups to gain data was particularly appropriate for this study because focus groups provides an environment where "participants feel comfortable, respected, and free to give their opinion without being judged" (Krueger & Casey, 2009).

Data Collection

✓ Started in summer 2011 after obtaining Institutional Review Board approval

✓ Email invitations were sent out to recruit students in TRiO and Access To Success Programs

✓ After several weeks of recruiting, researchers conducted 9 focus groups

Participants

✓ 39 first-generation students participated across the 9 groups

✓ Demographics: 24 Females and 15 males

✓ Out of 39 students, 15 identified as immigrants, and 33 received the Federal Pell Grant as part of their financial aid package to college

✓ Race broke down across cohorts as follows:

-10 Asian/Pacific Islander

-19 African American

-2 Caucasian

-8 Identified themselves a multi-racial

Data Analysis

✓ Thus far 3 of the 9 focus group sessions were transcribed for preliminary analysis

✓ To ensure inter-rater reliability, 3 readers individually coded the transcripts to arrive at themes which were discussed till we arrived at a saturation of categories

✓ Through a process of "categorical aggregation" (Lincoln and Guba, 1985) six meta-themes emerged

Preliminary Analysis

1. **Visible/Invisible**: Exemplifies the isolation of FG students who felt simultaneously alone and also singled out as representatives of their social class, ethnicity or race.
2. **Different Worlds:** Speaks to how FG students were torn between the culture, expectations and obligations of their home and school worlds.
3. **Perpetual Border Crossers:** Characterizes the ways in which FG students were continually seeking to balance the demands of their multiple and often competing identities and worlds.
4. **Burden of Privilege:** Expresses how FG students felt both privileged and burdened by the opportunity to earn a degree especially in how they sought to balance their own dreams with a sense of personal responsibility that they felt for their families and communities.
5. **Getting to Know the System:** Refers to the ways in which FG students tried to allocate resources and to navigate their way into the university system.
6. **A Call to Genuine Institutional Commitment:** Captures how institutions could better support and understand FG students.